Trapped in the Shadows (She-Ra / Korra crossover)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/24224392.

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Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), Avatar: Legend of Korra

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Korra/Asami Sato

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Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Korra (Avatar), Asami Sato, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Riko OC

Additional Tags:
Orphans, Orphanage, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Abuse, Angst, Crossover, High School, AU, Trauma, LGBTQ, OC

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by KidWolff

Summary

When an orphan goes missing, it raises a lot of questions at the orphanage - of the kind of treatment children are receiving there and if people are doing their jobs. Catra finds a place to train her to get revenge. Adora stresses about her and tries her best to help everyone. Riko (oc from my Korra story) fights her own demons at the orphanage and gets pulled into the revenge that is meant to take place. TW for physical abuse and mental abuse, abuse of power.

Notes

OC notes: Riko - is from my Korra story and was the adoptive child of Korra/Asami. She an earthbender and rough around the edges but cares deeply. She deals with some self-hate from abandonement.
Kohaku - is also from my Korra story and is the second adopted child. He's a bold firebender and can be a little obnoxious and nosy.
Nami - the youngest of the adoptive kids in my Korra story. She's a waterbender who was kind in her childhood but grew cold towards her new siblings.
Karina - Riko's love interest.
Just to clear things up: In my Korra story, they are adopted right away. In THIS story, they start in an orphanage.

Chapter 1

Republic City… A city of life. Of culture. Of substance. It had been the creation of all of the nations uniting for a common cause. The land had been in chaos for so long. They hoped making a city meant for all people would help stop the fighting. It made things rougher at first, but now, almost 30 years later, people were learning to trust each other again.

Riko wandered down the hall slowly, hands in her pockets, eyes looking down. She knew being called to the headmistress's office was bad. Every other time had gone badly. It wasn't bad for everyone, though. Some kids were obvious favorites.
"Now get out!" A loud voice echoed down the hall.
The door slammed open and a tan girl was thrown out. Riko winced as she landed on her butt with a thump. She peeked open and noted the girl's wild mane, cat ears, and markings on her arms. She particularly noticed the side of her face was redder than normal.
'Catra.'
The two of them met eyes for less than a second and then Catra ran off. Riko took a deep breath and steeled herself. Ms. Weaver didn't have to say a word for her, just motioned her inside.

Catra ran until she reached the rooftop. She stopped to catch her breath and then sat near the edge to watch the city. The hustle and bustle of Republic City was always a good distraction. The door to the roof creaked open and Catra scowled, knowing exactly who followed her.
A shoulder bumped into hers as her best friend sat down next to her. "Want to talk about it?"
Catra huffed and crossed her arms. "What's to talk about? It's just like every time."
Blonde hair swirled with the wind. A quiet laugh came from her and she unraveled Catra's arms. "It's okay, Catra. You want to talk about the rest of your day?"
The sky was turning dark orange, with blue peeking out. Catra began to relax. "Not really, Adora. I just want to go to bed."

Adora blinked in surprise. Her best friend was usually so fired up. What had happened in the headmistress's office to make her like this?
She shook her head. "Alright, Catra. Let's head back inside then."
Catra looked up at her with wide eyes as Adora stood up and stretched her hand out to help her up. Then she smiled, grateful that Adora let it go so easily, and grabbed her hand.

"I'm reaching my breaking point with you, Riko."
Riko gulped and kept her head down. "I understand, Headmistress."
"Do you?! This is not the first fight you've been in! And they seem to be getting worse! This is not acceptable behavior to come from the Horde Orphanage! You want to get adopted right?!"
Riko quietly took in the verbal abuse and shrank into herself. Of course, she wanted to get adopted, but what Ms. Weaver didn't care about was that Riko was protecting other orphans at school.
Suddenly the verbal assault stopped. Riko cautiously looked up. Weaver stood a few feet away. A mask covered her face from an accident long ago. "You're just like her… You're not listening. So, this is the punishment."
Riko went wide-eyed as shadows rolled out from Weaver's sleeves. She stood up straight and tried to explain herself. "Please, Headmistress! I was trying to help the other kids."
Everything stopped for just a second, then Weaver's hand rose to control the shadows. "I know."

Riko stumbled down the girl's hall, left arm limp at her side. It wasn't broke, far from it, but the pain was too strong to use it. She groaned as the pain spiked and glanced down. The shadows had cut into her arm like a snare and burned any skin that it touched. She tapped her head on the wall, forcing herself to focus long enough to get back to her room.
Catra and Adora quietly rounded the corner at the intersection and it was then that they noticed droplets of blood on the floor.
"Someone's hurt." Adora said.
Catra looked away. "Let's just go."
"Catra!"
"What?! People are always getting hurt!"

“Not usually enough to bleed!”
Catra didn’t respond as she saw the owner of the blood and pointed a clawed finger down the hall.
Riko stood on one knee, grasping at the wall. She was almost there, to her room, and no one would know what happened.
That’s when she heard their arguing and glanced back. Riko and Catra met eyes, just like earlier. Riko whipped back around, pushing herself to get up. She didn’t need their help.
Adora took a step to her before being stopped by her best friend. “She’s hurt, Catra!”
Catra sadly shook her head, ears flat against her head. “She’s fine. She’s almost to her room. Let her go.”
Adora refused and looked back at the girl just in time to see Riko grab her own room’s doorknob and disappear inside.
“I told you, now let’s go.” Catra said and urged her to return to her own room.
Riko scowled once inside. “Who are you?”
A young girl sat on the other bed in the room, which had been empty for weeks. No one had been roomed with Riko in a while.
The girl hopped up and fiddled with her fingers. “My name’s Nami. I arrived today.”
“Tch, just go to bed and act like you didn’t see me like this.” Riko replied roughly.
Nami looked at her questionably. “You’re hurt?”
Riko smiled painfully. “Yeah, better get used to it. The Headmistress doesn’t like disobedient children.”
She rolled onto her bed, not bothering with the covers, and passed out.

“Where were you?” A boy asked.
Riko huffed and kept walking. “You didn’t hear? I was suspended for a day for fighting.”
The boy, which had become one of Riko’s best friends at the orphanage, hadn’t meant the fight.
“I mean with Shadow Weaver. I didn’t see you at all yesterday.”
Riko frantically looked around, making sure no other orphans were around, sighing when she saw none. “Would you stop with the nickname? If someone hears that, you’ll get called up there too,

Kohaku."
The boy glanced at her bandaged arm. "Just like you did two days ago."
Riko froze, and then breathed in deeply. "If anyone asks you, you tell them I hurt myself in training."
"Why?! If people knew what Weaver was doing!"
"Then we'd never find homes." Riko finished sadly.
Kohaku blinked, then scowled. "I don't believe that. We'd be better off without her."
Riko shrugged nonchalantly. "Guess we'll never know. Keep walking. We're almost to school."

Riko tugged on her left sleeve, making sure it would cover her injured arm. Not that anyone cared, but she didn't want to deal with the questions. It wasn't too suspicious to wear layers since it was autumn.
"Riko!"
The girl groaned and looked back. Her only friend in school, oh so chipper, ran up to her. "Hey! You're back!"
"Yeah, Karina, we all know they didn't want to suspend me, but they had to for a day." Riko replied tiredly.
"Well! I say we get a treat after school! What do you think?" Karina asked.
Riko rose a brow. "For what? Getting suspended?"
Karina chuckled and grabbed her hand to pull her to class. "No, silly, for doing the right thing."
Karina waited for a reply but got none. She glanced over and saw panic on the girl's face. "Riko? You okay?"
Riko jumped and yanked her hand away, pulling it behind her. "Yeah! Everything's fine! Why?!"
Riko internally groaned as she saw her friend's mind working a mile a minute trying to figure out what upset her. "C'mon, let's get to class!"
Karina sighed and followed her antsy friend. "Alright."
To Riko's frustration, her friend was determined to figure out what was wrong and kept pestering her all morning.
"I told you, I'm fine!" Riko finally blew up at lunch.
Karina sat surprised at her friend's outburst. She knew of her

situation as an orphan and knew it probably wasn't an easy life, but Riko had never been this triggered before. Something happened while she was suspended. Karina's heart sank as she began piecing everything together. She quickly yanked her friend out of her seat and forced her to the bathroom.
"Hey, what're you doing?!" Riko demanded. She turned around angrily and gasped as Karina stood between her and the exit.
"Talk."
Riko growled with anger and pulled her hand into fists. "It's none of your damn business, Karina. Now let me out."
"I'm not your enemy here, Riko. I'm your friend, one that's concerned that something happened once you got home from that fight."
"Right now, it doesn't feel like you're my friend!" Riko yelled, pulling the metal from the stall doors with a squeeze of her fist.
Karina narrowed her eyes at her as she pulled water from the faucet with a smooth motion of her hand.
The two stood there with their elements in the air in front of them, ready to fight.
Karina's jaw was tense as she spoke. "I'm guessing something really bad happened for you to want to fight me, and with your earthbending, nonetheless."
Riko chuckled, but it almost didn't even sound like her. "You're one to talk. You're ready to waterbend at me."
They stared at each other for a minute before Karina released the water back into the sink. "I'm not the enemy. I want to help."
Riko stood, huffing, trying to figure out an easy solution to her problem. Tears began to prick the corners of her eyes.
"Riko?" Karina was surprised. Her friend never cried.
Her arms slowly fell, carefully dropping the metal. She took a deep, shaky breath. "I can't do this."
Riko shoved her friend to the side and dashed out of the bathroom. "Riko!"
Riko ran out of the cafeteria, outside to a hidden alley of the school.
Catra eyed the orphan as she ran out of the room, watching as her friend yelled at her with worry. On the outside, she remained neutral, but on the inside, she was shocked to see tears falling

from Riko's eyes. Adora followed Catra's sight and watched with her own worry. "She's hurt."
Catra snorted and glanced back. "Oh gee, what made you think that?"
Adora frowned and whispered in her ear. "Maybe the fact that we saw she was bleeding and did nothing to help her! And now she's pushing people away."
Catra pushed her back gently. "How would you know she's pushing people away? We barely even know her."
Adora sat back and crossed her arms. "I see her working with the younger kids sometimes. She helps Kyle with training. Helps Lonnie with homework. Comforts Rogelio when he's upset. She cares for people."
Catra froze mid-drink at the new knowledge and glanced back at Adora. "She does?"
Adora smiled gently. "You would see that if you helped around sometime."
Catra huffed and sat her drink down. "I help!"
Adora went to ruffle the girl's hair, but Catra's tail caught her hand midair. "Sure you do."

Kohaku found Riko already waiting for him after school. He rose a brow. "You're early."
Riko sniffed and turned to walk home. Kohaku jumped up quickly to follow her. "H-Hey, you alright? How was your day?"
Riko rubbed her eyes. "It was fine, kid. I just want to go home."
Kohaku looked away despondently. "Me too…"
Where they were going certainly did not feel like home.

That night, Catra rolled back and forth in bed, which meant she would eventually wake up her friend.
Earlier, Adora had taken Catra to the lunch room of the orphanage where kids went to converse. Usually Riko was there helping kids with homework or just talking to them. Catra hid her eagerness to see this girl helping people, but they quickly found out she wasn't there. Adora saw the disappointment in Catra and had sighed. She wanted Catra to see the good in people. Catra crossed her arms and walked away, mentioning that Riko wasn't being very helpful now.

“Catraaa, stop moving so much.” Adora groaned from the top of the bed.
Catra curled herself at her friend’s feet. “Sorry, Adora, can’t sleep.”
Adora blinked the sleep from her eyes and sat up. “Wanna talk about it?”
Catra groaned and faceplanted in the bed. “Well…” She lifted her head. “I’ve been thinking about what it would be like to leave here, like escape, not adopted. Not many kids are adopted now. In fact, I think more kids are coming in now rather than leaving. This is no life for a kid, let alone with that evil witch punishing us for even the smallest thing. She’s not helping us.”
Adora grabbed her friend’s hand and pulled her up to sit with her. “I don’t know why everyone says Ms. Weaver is so bad. She’s doing the best she can.” Adora replied.
Catra growled and yanked her hand back. “She hurts kids, Adora. Riko’s arm looks like that because of Weaver.”
“I don’t agree with the methods, but Riko had to have a consequence for fighting.”
Catra sneered at her. “Yeah? And what was your punishment for fighting at school?!”
Adora froze. “I… scrubbing the floor.”
“Scrubbing the floor… Do you see it?! You and Riko did the same thing but had two very different punishments! That girl’s arm is mangled, and she was fighting to protect someone!”
Adora ran a hand through her hand, but Catra wasn’t done. “And you’re one of Weaver’s favorites.”
Adora whipped up quickly. “What?”
“You are. I don’t know why, but you don’t get harsh punishments like some of us do.” Catra continued.
Adora looked away, pondering. “What was your punishment when you went two days ago?”
Catra sighed. “Some mean words, nothing I can’t handle.”
“And that fading bruise on your cheek?”
Catra looked away, giving Adora a good view of her bruised face. She realized this and quickly turned back to hide her cheek. Adora gently grabbed the side of her face and made her look at her. Catra always tried to act tough, but her past was too rough to not have some cracks in her armor. Adora could see her armor falling

as tears appeared in the corner of her eyes. Catra pulled her face tight so none would fall.
"I'm sorry."
And the armor was broken.
Tears fell from Catra's eyes and she covered her face. Adora pulled her into her embrace and let her cry on her shoulder. She repeated those words over and over again until Catra calmed down.
Catra pulled away and took a deep breath.
"Thanks." She whispered.
Adora nodded and pulled them down to lay back in bed. She pulled the cat-girl closer as she curled up into her stomach. "Next time you're called to Weaver's office, I'm going with you."
"What? No!" Catra jumped up. Fear was evident in her dual-colored eyes. "You can't! She'll hurt you, too."
Adora carefully petted her hair. "It'll be okay. She won't hurt either of us with me there. I'll make sure of it."
New fear was coursing through Catra, but Adora patted her good cheek and motioned for her to lay down. She sighed and curled back into Adora's stomach.
Adora whispered as she petted her head. "Don't worry about it for now, just rest."

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

Riko admits that something bad is going on at the orphanage. Catra proves to Adora that she really is Weaver's favorite.

Chapter Notes

Just a reminder if you're joining in now - TW for abuse.

Kohaku glanced around the lunch room. Breakfast time was almost over and Riko still hadn't come from her room for breakfast. Her new roommate Nami had come down. This only worried the young firebender. He tried to wait for her in the hallway, hoping he could pass on the apple he had saved for her at least. He glanced at the clock on the wall. If they didn't go soon, they'd be late for school. He sighed and grabbed his bag from the floor.
"Hey squirt."
He glanced up and smiled. "Hey, you ready?"
Riko smiled and nodded, letting him lead the way.
"I saved an apple for you." Kohaku said once they were walking on the main street. Riko gratefully took it and began eating.
"Where were you at anyway?"
Riko's smile faded as she finished a bite. "I was just thinking about things. Sorry I missed breakfast."
Kohaku glanced back at her, then put his hands behind his head. "Alright, just let me know if you want to talk."
Riko gave a small smile. The boy knew just what to say to make her feel better.
The two of them waved at each other once they got to school. Kohaku was still in middle school, but it was only the next building over.
"Riko!"
The earthbender whipped around and grimaced. "Oh no."
Kohaku chuckled and quickly ran to the school. "Good luck!"
"Riko, how do you feel today?" Karina asked.

“Karina, I’m really sorry about yesterday. You were right about things and I guess it just scared me.” Riko explained, head down. This is what she had been thinking about all morning.
Karina blinked, surprised how easily Riko was talking about what happened. She had been ready for a repeat of the previous day.
“Let’s walk and talk.”
Riko nodded and followed her friend.
“Lift your head, would you? It suits you much better.” Karina commented.
Riko quickly lifted her head, not in obedience but in shock. Karina was usually so happy and comforting, but even words like that struck a cord in Riko. Karina looked over and smiled at her. Riko could feel her face getter warm and sucked in air.
“Now, we’ve got some time before class. Do you want to actually talk about what happened?” Karina asked once they reached her locker.
“Uhh.” Riko rubbed the back of her head. “I mean, you were right, like always. I did have a punishment when I got home after the fight. It was one of the worst ones yet, but I’m okay now. Just needed time to process it…”
Karina quietly listened to her. “And why did that scare you?”
“Huh?”
“You said earlier that it scared you. Why?”
Riko looked down again, trying to come up with an excuse. Almost instantly, a hand lifted her head back up and she came eye-to-eye with Karina.
“I told you, you look better when you look up.” Karina said. This time the blush on Riko’s face was obvious. “Now, tell me why it scared you.”
Riko shook herself loose and almost looked down again but caught herself. “I don’t know.”
They stood there for a minute as Karina finished switching books in her locker. She swung her bag on her back.
“Maybe it would help if I saw what she did to you.” Karina said carefully.
Riko gasped. “I-I don’t think… Wait, how do you know she did something to me?”
Karina let out a sad chuckle. “Besides the fact that you just

confirmed it, you panicked yesterday when I grabbed your hand. And I know it had nothing to do with your crush on me because I grab your hand all of the time."
Riko momentarily freaked out that Karina knew about your crush. "Wait, you know about that?!"
Karina let out a louder laugh now. "Yes, Riko, how could I not? Now you're evading the question."
Riko crossed her arms. "Technically you didn't ask a question."
Karina huffed and stood pointedly. "Fine, I'll rephrase it. What did Weaver do to you?"
Hearing it aloud made fear course through her once again. Riko dropped her arms and tried to respond, but just stuttered with her words. Karina saw her panic rising and pulled her to an area under the stairwell.
"Riko, you have to calm down." Karina urged her. She grabbed both of her hands and rubbed her thumbs over the backs of her hands.
"I-It just…worst thing ever… I don't know if anyone's ever had a punishment like that…" Riko stuttered.
As Karina was rubbing her hands, her thumb touched something under her sleeve. She felt both of her wrists, wondering if maybe it was another shirt under her jacket. She only felt the material on her left arm. Her own panic began to rise, but she pushed it away for her friend's sake.
Karina carefully let both of her hands touch her friend's left hand. Riko wasn't responding anymore and watched. Karina wondered if Riko wanted this. She carefully rolled up the left sleeve of the jacket, but she maintained eye contact with Riko, hoping it would help distract her from her arm. She didn't look away until she felt Riko's skin under the sleeve again. She took a breath and glanced down.
Karina gasped when she saw that the span of Riko's forearm was bandaged, from her wrist to her elbow. "What happened?" She whispered.
Riko cautiously took her hand back and started undoing the bandages. Karina quickly grabbed her hand again. "Should you do that?"
"Heh, it doesn't matter. Besides, I think it'll answer your

questions.” Riko replied and was finally able to pull the bandages away.
Saying she was shocked was an understatement. Karina stood there, unable to believe what Riko’s arm looked like. There was a single, deep cut all the way around her forearm. All of the skin within about 3 inches was scorched and red.
“How the hell did this happen?” Karina whispered.
Riko chuckled and began rolling the bandages back on. “You don’t know Weaver.”
“You’re right, I don’t know her, but I do know that no one is supposed to hurt kids like this, especially if they’re under their care. What she’s doing is wrong!” Karina was yelling by the end of it.
Riko quickly put a hand to her mouth. “Not so loud! It’s not like I can do anything about it!”
“What do you mean?! Go to the police!”
“Yeah and have Weaver hurt us more than ever while the police take their time to investigate? No thanks!” Riko answered.
Sometime during all of this, the first bell had rung. Karina groaned and pinched her nose. “Just don’t do anything else to piss her off like that again. I can’t stand to see you like this. Now c’mon, we’re late for class.” Karina said, pulling Riko to class.
Riko had been happy that Karina was going to let it go, at least for now.
However, when they got to class, it wasn’t long before Karina approached their math teacher. Riko stopped working on the math problems and watched them talk. She couldn’t hear them, they were whispering. She mentally groaned and looked back to her paper.
“Mrs. Sato, I need your help with something.” Karina started. She brought her paper with her to make Riko think she was asking about the work.
Karina leaned on the teacher’s desk to whisper. “I have to tell you something and I need you to not react to it. It’s about Riko and she’s probably watching and will be furious if I tell anyone.”
Asami Sato slid her glasses off her face. She knew very little about Riko, only that she’s an orphan who received average grades.
“You have my full attention. Is Riko okay?”

Karina gulped. She couldn't look back, Riko would know for sure then. "She's not okay. She's injured."
Asami felt her throat go dry. "Does she need medical attention?"
Karina shook her head and pointed at something at her paper, still pretending it was about the work. Asami followed her finger and saw a name. 'Weaver.'
Asami quickly looked back at the girl. She knew that was the name of the woman in charge of the orphanage. The girl's hardened look told her all she needed to know. "I see. I will reach out to people who can help."
Asami stood up smiling and handed the paper back to the girl. She spoke a little louder so Riko could hear. "You figured out that problem, just needed a little help. Good job!"
Karina quickly figured out Mrs. Sato's idea. "Ah, yes! Thank you!" She quickly slid back to her seat.
Riko watched with confusion. Had Karina really just asked about the math work? She sighed.
Asami watched carefully as to not let Riko know what was going on. But if Asami was going to get help, she would need proof. She grabbed a sheet of paper and wrote the name 'Riko' at the top.

Catra groaned at the lunch table, her head down into her crossed arms. Adora finally joined her for lunch and rose a brow. "What's up with you?"
Catra rolled her head to the side, giving her friend a look. "You should know, you're smart."
Adora sighed and sat down. "Let me see it."
Catra groaned louder and pulled the crumbled paper from her pocket. Adora took it from her hand and read it. Her eyes went wide with realization. "Catra, Weaver's not going to like this."
The girl snatched the paper back with a hiss. "You think I don't know that already! Two F's and three D's! Yeah I think that about calls for some punishment!"
Adora sighed and rubbed the bridge of her nose. "Like I said, I'll go with you."
"Yeah? So you can play hero?" Catra growled back. "You think you can fix everything, but newsflash, you can't!" Catra let her head thump back on the table. "I'm really going to get it this time…"

Adora squeezed her hands, angry with her friend's outburst but understanding the reason. "I'm not going to let you get hurt! Not like Riko…"
Catra chuckled. "You realize how ridiculous that sounds right? You know she hurts people and you still can't see the truth… Riko helps everyone yet she still gets punished. No one's there to protect her. What makes you think this will be different?"
Adora smiled. "Like you said, I'm one of her favorites."
Catra blinked and lifted her head back up. "Heh, if you think that'll help…"

It didn't help. If anything, it made things worse.
When the duo arrived at the orphanage and walked to the Headmistress's office, they saw there was already a line of several kids waiting to receive punishments for bad report cards. This wasn't too uncommon, and these punishments weren't so bad. Usually. And like usual, Riko was in line, too. Riko and Catra met eyes and quickly looked in different directions.
The duo sat down and Catra nudged her. "You're going to see it right now. The favoritism that goes on here."
It took several kids going in and out for Adora to finally start to understand.
The first kid went in and everyone could hear the verbal abuse happening behind closed doors. No one was happy to be here. The boy ran out crying and the second kid went in cautiously. She received a light scolding and double chores for the week. She quietly walked away.
Riko was next. She sighed deeply and stood strong. Adora sat tensely, wondering what the girl's outcome would be. It started with some yelling, then a resounding smack and a thud. There was the sound of scuffling feet, then Riko was yelling back at Weaver. Everyone waiting outside, even Adora, knew this was a bad idea. Riko let out a quick scream, startling them. Riko's struggle was evident from the sounds. Another thud came close to the door, making Adora jump. Everything went quiet, then suddenly the door was yanked open and Riko was thrown out. She cried out in pain as she laid on the floor and the next child walked in.

Riko was breathing very shakily. Adora watched in anxiety. "We have to help her, Catra."
The cat-girl remained seated, ears pulled back. "We can't."
"Why not?!"
Catra growled and whipped around to her. "Because if we try to help her it'll be us that gets it worse! Trust me, I know…"
Dozens of questions formed in Adora's mind, but now wasn't the time to ask, not when they were next in line.
Riko eased herself up on one arm. Her injured arm was bleeding again. Weaver had reopened the wound on purpose. The girl knew she would likely have bruises elsewhere as a result of her arguing back. She staggered to her feet, letting her arm hang once again, and began the trek back to her room.
Adora watched her retreating form until the door opened again and the last child ran away.
"Ready?" Catra asked.
Adora braced herself and nodded. Together they walked into the office.
"Ahh, Catra, what a surprise." Weaver commented sarcastically. "Now Adora? That does surprise me. Why are you here?"
The two of them glanced at each other. Catra looked fine, but Adora could sense the fear. "I'm here just as moral support for Catra."
Weaver laughed, which was rare and worried the girls. "Leave us Adora. If Catra did something, it's her that needs punished, not you."
Adora scowled. "And what if I did something?"
"Like what?"
"Disobey you."
The air went cold. Fear was starting to grow in both girls.
Suddenly a hand reached out and grabbed Catra by the neck.
"Catra!"
"You did this, Catra. You turned my most loyal servant against me. You ruined her!" Weaver yelled, holding the girl in the air. "You good-for-nothing! You ruin everything you touch! Every friend betrayed you, every relative left you. No one wants you! You defiant little monster! Now I will ruin everything left for you!"
During this verbal attack, Adora was yelling and pulling at

Weaver's arm to let Catra go. However, Catra was putting up no fight. She simply took the words in and was left breathless from being held up.
Finally, Weaver let go of the cat-girl. Adora didn't bother waiting for another word from Weaver. She grabbed her friend and ran out of the room with her.
When Adora finally approached their door, she threw it open, carried Catra to the bed, and slammed the door shut.
"Catra, look at me." Adora whispered, grabbing her hands.
The girl was breathing like normal again, so she was probably okay. At least physically. "Catra, what she said back there wasn't true! You know that. She's trying to hurt you where she knows it hurts with her words."
"It's okay, Adora." Catra whispered back. "You don't have to protect me or act like I'm some good person. I deserved what I got back there. And honestly it will probably be worse next time since you cut her time short."
The room was quiet, neither knowing what to say next. Quiet tears rolled down Catra's cheeks, but she wouldn't feel sorry for herself.
Adora grabbed Catra's hand with new strength. "Let's leave together."
Catra finally looked at her friend. She had never seen such a fire in her eyes. Usually it was Catra with the fire. "Heh, what a crazy idea."
"Crazy?! You're the one who was just talking about running away the other night!" Adora responded.
"Adora… You have a chance here." Catra spoke quietly. Adora's eyes widened the more she spoke. "You're one of the only kids who has a shot at being adopted. If you leave with me, you're throwing that away. And I won't let you do that. You need to find a good family, one that has Christmas every year, and has summer vacations, and can pay for the things you need. Hell, even get you to college… I'm a nobody. I won't find a place here. No one would care if I left."
Adora felt rage building up near the end of Catra's speech. "I would care if you left!"
Catra blinked in surprise and sat up to look at her. They stared

into each other's eyes, then Catra narrowed her eyes at her. "No, you wouldn't."
"I would! You've been my best friend since we arrived here as kids. I absolutely would throw away my chance at a family if it meant being with you!" Adora yelled. Catra gasped. "Because you are my family…" Adora finished quieter.
Catra watched as tears began falling from her friend's eyes. Things were starting to make sense now. And she felt like a fool for not seeing it earlier, even though that was how she felt for years.
She eased forward on her hands. Adora welcomed her closer by putting a hand on her cheek. There was a pause as they stopped inches away from each other.
"Adora…I've felt the same for a long time."
Adora pulled her the rest of the way to her and their lips met at last. She moved to sit on the bed next to Catra to be closer together. Her hand carefully ran through Catra's hair. The other hand rested on her cheek.
Catra groaned as she moved to make room for the girl. This was what she had been wanting for so long. She pushed back gently, not wanting Adora to get too confident.
As the need for air grew, they finally separated.
"I'm definitely not going anywhere now, not without you." Adora said.
Catra smiled, an honest smile for the first time in a long time, and laughed. "You're such a dummy. I still say that if the chance comes, you should take it."
Adora seemed to be thinking for a minute. "If it happens, I'll convince them to take you too."
Catra went wide-eyed, then suddenly hugged Adora tight. Adora smiled sadly and started petting her hair again.

Catra stood at the entrance of the orphanage, bag heavy on her back. She was fighting internally about whether to go back or not. Having just had that special moment with Adora made the decision hard, but then again it should've made the decision easier.
Catra lifted her head, not looking back. 'I'm doing this for her.'

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

> Chaos starts to ensue. Pieces start falling into place. Catra finds some new friends who help her get stronger in order to make things right. Riko deals with the complications of admitting her truth. Adults start getting involved in solving the mysteries of the orphanage.

Catra was in such a rush to get to the roof that she didn't notice a guest already there. She quickly caught her breath from dashing up the stairs two at a time and looked at the person's back. They were sitting towards the city, just like Catra liked to do. She noticed the girl had the same shirt on from two days ago because she recognized the bloody lashes in her back.

The cat-girl quietly approached her as to not startle her. "Hey."

Riko glanced back. "Hey…"

Catra gently sat down beside her. "Riko, right?"

The earthbender nodded. Her small body huddled around her knees as the wind chilled her. "Thanks for earlier…" Riko spoke quietly.

Catra thought back to two days ago when both of them were ordered to the Headmistress's office simultaneously. They didn't know what to expect. Being so young, they hadn't experienced the worst that Weaver had to offer until that day. Riko went in first. It wasn't long before her shrieks filled the hall at the sound of a whip. Catra panicked outside and forced her way in. She was shocked when she saw Riko on her knees with 3 fresh lashes across her back from a shadow coming from Weaver's hands. She had yelled at Weaver, asking why she was doing that, that she was hurting Riko. Weaver apparently didn't like someone interrupting and quickly ordered her shadows to control Catra.

Catra was paralyzed and forced to watch Riko take another lash. Weaver had stopped momentarily in thought, then decided that Catra would take the rest of Riko's punishment. Riko was literally thrown out, back hitting the hallway wall, and she could only struggle to move as she listened to Catra's screams.

Catra didn't have the heart to tell her that she had received nearly triple the amount of lashes as a result. "It was no problem. She shouldn't have done that to you."

Riko took a good look at her. "She did it to you too."

"Ah, it wasn't so bad. I've had worse." Catra was lying.

Riko huffed and looked back to the city. "When we get out of here, I want to make this a better place."

Catra followed her gaze. "You mean the city? Or this place?"

Riko growled and lifted her head. "I mean here! This shouldn't be how kids live, in fear of what consequences their actions will have. It's not right."

They sat quietly, listening to the sounds of the city for a moment. "I'm with you on that." They glanced at each other. "And I'm going to hold you to it that you keep your word on that. And I'll do the same."

Catra gave a devilish smirk like always, her mind was made up. Riko smirked, too, and nodded her head in agreement.

Riko thought back to that night 7 years ago. While everyone else was panicking, Riko knew, or at least hoped, that Catra had a plan.

Earlier, Adora had rushed to the cafeteria in a panic, telling the staff that she couldn't find Catra. Staff and kids scoured the whole building for her, but no one could find her. Riko tried to stay

neutral so that no one would suspect she knew something, which she honestly didn't know anything.

Kohaku and Nami were waiting for her at the entrance and together they walked to school. While their morning had been exciting, Riko was happy to leave that place and go to school. At least until classes started. Her teachers were acting weird today, trying to help her more than normal, asking her odd questions. By lunchtime, she was annoyed. She quietly retrieved her tray and moved toward her table where Karina was waiting. She had some questions for her, but then she noticed Adora sitting alone and sad. She remembered, Catra's gone, and averted her course. Karina watched with worry.

"Hey."

Adora looked up, trying not to cry. "Riko, right?"

Riko smirked, thinking that those were the same words Catra first spoke to her. "Yeah, you want to come sit with me?"

Adora blinked in surprise. Riko motioned to her table, which consisted of Karina and Karina's friends. She sighed. "Sure, what do I have to lose?"

Riko chuckled. "That's the spirit." Riko carried both of their trays and guided her to their table.

Karina waved. "Hi, I'm Karina."

Adora nodded and introduced herself. "Adora."

Riko huffed and crossed her arms. "C'mon now, stop being so mopey."

Adora gaped and struggled with her emotions. "You! Tch, aren't you worried?!"

Riko rose a brow. "No, why would I be?"

Adora groaned. “Because Catra’s missing! No note, no talk, all of her belongings gone, nothing was left behind!”

Riko chuckled and began working on her meal. “You worry too much. She’ll be fine.”

Adora watched with narrowed eyes. “What do you know that I don’t?”

Riko froze mid-bite. “I-I… I honestly don’t know anything. I only keep thinking about a talk we had years ago.”

Adora scrunched her brows. “You two don’t talk. In fact, you act like you barely know each other.”

Riko sighed and set her fork down. “There’s a reason… When we were like 8 years old, we both were called to the Headmistress’s office. We had no idea what was going to happen that day, and what would continue since then.”

She glanced over and saw that Karina was listening intently but continued anyway. She knew she was providing ammunition, but to hell with it. “It was the worst punishment we had gotten up until that point. Catra stood up for me, which resulted in a harsher punishment for her, but it only made our resolve stronger… Later, we sat on the roof together and talked about the future, about leaving here and making things better, not just for us, but for everyone.”

The three of them sat there quietly in thought.

Riko sighed deeply. “That’s why I’m not worried. We made a promise to each other that if we left, it would be to change things.”

Adora looked at Riko in a new light. “You think she’s out there getting help?”

Riko’s hands had balled into fists on the table by now. “Yeah, I have no doubt she’s up to something to help us.”

"Riko…"

The girl looked up at the sound of her name. She saw Karina looking worried. "What was the punishment that night?"

Riko sat up straight, not anticipating that question. She gulped. "I-I don't think now's the time for that."

"I think now is definitely the time for that! How can we help if we don't know what all happened that night?!" Karina argued. She needed this information.

Riko narrowed her eyes. She knew Karina was up to something, too. "I'll show you when all of this is said and done."

Karina quietly gasped and her anger disappeared. Riko growled as her anger increased and she stormed off. Karina looked down. '*I'll show you*… That means something was done to her.'

At the end of the school day, Karina walked towards her math class. She had to talk to Mrs. Sato. As she approached the door, she heard chatter from inside. She knocked and was surprised when another teacher opened the door.

"Karina? What're you doing here?" Mrs. Sato asked from her desk.

Karina peeked around the teacher in front of her and saw a handful of other teachers, along with a woman she had never seen before. "Are… Are you all talking about Riko?"

The teachers around the room appeared startled and looked to Asami for guidance. The woman sighed, planting her hand on some papers. "Yes, Karina, why don't you come in?"

Karina nodded and took a seat at a desk like the other teachers. An odd woman was standing near Mrs. Sato's desk. She had tan skin and short brown hair. That's when she noticed the police badge on her chest. 'The police are getting involved.' She wasn't sure if she was happy or worried.

“We are discussing Riko. I had asked her other teachers to keep an eye on her and to jot down any incidents from the past with her. We can’t help if we don’t have some kind of proof.” Asami explained. “Did you find out something new?”

Karina’s anxiety must have been obvious, and she nodded. “We were talking at lunch today, and Riko mentioned something from her past. Like from a long time ago, and she said it continues today still. She said something was done to her, but she won’t show me until this is done, whatever that means.”

The teachers were listening intently. The police woman glanced at her math teacher.

Karina had one more thing to share. “A kid from the orphanage just went missing without a trace. They don’t know what happened to her. That has to be enough to start an investigation.”

The tan woman crossed her arms. “There’s already an investigation started, but all of this might just be enough to press charges.”

New joy erupted in Karina’s chest. “Really?!”

Asami nodded and stood up, placing a hand on the officer’s shoulder. “This is my wife, Korra. She’s a police officer, very high up in rank, and she’s personally taken on this case.”

“Thank you!” Karina exclaimed happily.

Korra chuckled and waved her off. “My only question is, do you think you can get Riko to cooperate?”

Karina deflated and leaned back in her seat. “I doubt it. I tried to get her to go to the police before and she was terrified.”

Korra and Asami shared a glance. Korra smiled back at Karina. “That’s alright. Maybe I’ll get a chance to talk to her once things come to light. Thanks for the help.”

Karina nodded and exited the classroom. Korra sighed and looked to her wife.

"If she's terrified of coming to the police, something really bad might be happening in that orphanage." Korra explained.

Catra wandered the streets for two days. She was stuck eating scraps and dodging the police. She was searching the city for something. She had seen a newspaper ad for martial arts training and meditation, but when she arrived there she was turned away by a bald man with strange blue tattoos. She sighed as she left, not knowing a plan B.

She continued wandering the city, hoping something better would pop out to her. She wasn't sure how many days had passed since she left the orphanage. She thought about Adora but knew she would be fine. She ran into thieves and creeps but managed to fight them back. She was quickly growing tired, surviving on pretty much nothing.

"Hey, it's that girl!"

Catra looked back and saw some thugs who she had stolen food from the previous day. She laughed nervously before running away.

"Get back here! You owe us!"

"Like hell!" Catra yelled back. She had to get away fast. They could be benders or something else. Who knew with all the kinds of people in the city?

Catra weaved in and out of roads and alleys, hoping to lose them, but they kept up pretty close. She sped into another alley, hoping for a miracle. Suddenly an alley door opened, and she almost smacked into it.

“Hey, watch out!” Catra yelled, swerving around the door. On the other side, she saw a young girl with pink hair carrying a bag of trash.

“You watch it!” She yelled back.

They glared at each other before the sounds of running footsteps reminded Catra what was happening. She slinked back, ready to run again.

“Are you in trouble?” The girl asked.

Catra nodded and the new girl wasted no time in pulling Catra inside. They stood silently, afraid to alert the men of their hiding place. Catra held her breath, afraid to breathe until their footsteps started receding.

She sighed in relief and lowered her shoulders. “Thanks for that… I guess I should go-”

Catra was yanked back to go further into the building. “Hey, I don’t know you! Let me go!”

The girl stopped and looked at Catra. “I’m Glimmer. Do you want to something to eat?”

Catra chuckled. “Heh, your name is Glimmer? Like you were born with that name?”

Glimmer pouted. “Well, what’s your name?”

Catra rose a brow. “My name’s Catra.”

“Psh, what kind of name is Catra?” Glimmer mocked.

Catra blinked, then crossed her arms.

“Heh, that’s what I thought. Now, do you want to come sit? It looks like you haven’t eaten in a while.” Glimmer commented.

Catra sighed and nodded. Glimmer walked away after bringing the cat-girl to a table. Catra looked around and noticed it looked kind of like a shop. There were yoga mats, small weights, training gear, and lots of other things used to work out.

Glimmer returned with leftover meatloaf. "Here, it's the only thing that's already cooked and ready."

Catra had to stop herself from drooling and happily ate. Glimmer chuckled. The girl really hadn't eaten in days.

"What were you doing running from thugs?" Glimmer asked.

Catra paused, frowning as she remembered. "I had stolen some food from them yesterday. They chased after me when they recognized me."

Glimmer sighed. "Well, no more of that. You're welcome to stay here for the night." Then a thought hit Glimmer. "Do you have a home?"

Catra stopped eating again, this time in remorse. "I… Not really. It's complicated."

Glimmer rose a brow. "You ran away?"

"Eh, something like that. I'm looking for a place that can teach me."

Glimmer decided to let her finish her meal in peace. "I'll be right back. I'm going to run upstairs really quick for something."

Catra nodded, not minding at all. She didn't want to bother with questions like that. She heard footsteps coming back down the stairs and saw a tall woman gracefully walking towards her.

"Hello, I'm Angella. My daughter says you need help with something." Catra stuttered to re-explain herself when the woman held up a hand. "Come with me. I want to show you something and you can decide if it's what you're looking for."

Catra gave a small nod, setting her plate down, and followed her downstairs. She was shocked when she found that the basement was much bigger than it looked. It had to stretch out over several houses. There were areas split for meditation, training, and strategic discussions.

"We operate a training facility here and only allow select people in. Now, I don't know what my daughter saw in you, but she seems to think it would be a good idea to let you in." Angella explained.

Catra watched with awe at the people doing things around them, then hardened herself to look at the older woman. "I'm in."

Catra flipped to dodge an attack and pushed her own fighting rod outwards in response. Glimmer slid to dodge and fought back. They continued fighting until Catra landed a hit on her shoulder and a beeper sounded.

"Good job, Catra. You're picking this up pretty well." Angella commended.

"Heh, fighting is like second-nature to me." Catra gloated.

"While I do think you are a skilled fighter, I think there is much for you to improve on." Angella replied.

"Ah, I could probably take you on, Miss Angella." Catra bragged.

Angella rose a brow and the other students nearby froze. Glimmer was waving her arms frantically to warn the girl.

"Okay."

Catra turned in head in confusion. "Okay?"

"Okay, let's have a match."

Now Catra began to panic. “Ahh, I was just kidding! C’mon…”

Angella picked up her own fighting staff and stepped onto the mat. “Nope, you asked for it.”

Catra groaned and stepped back in position.

They cautiously circled each other, waiting for the other to make a move. Catra saw Angella’s feet begin to move and only ducked under her swinging staff in time. She rolled backwards and stabbed with her own rod. Both were able to dodge incoming attacks, Catra just barely moving in time mostly.

Angella swung her staff to the left. Catra predicted this and moved her staff to that side to deflect it, but just as she pulled her rod up, Angella stopped. The woman quickly reversed her attack to hit Catra on the right side. Catra couldn’t move in time and was slammed into the mat.

She groaned, easing herself up on her forearms. She froze when she felt the end of the staff pushing into her back. She hung her head in defeat and felt the pressure on her back lift up.

“Come…”

Catra looked up and saw Angella holding her hand out for her to take. She sighed and gratefully to the help to stand. “That was a well-fought match. I think you are improving.”

Catra smiled a toothy grin at the praise.

Catra gulped as she was losing her focus. Her hands trembled in their hold. Her legs were crossed tensely. Thoughts came freely to her mind, thoughts she wanted to avoid.

“Catra…”

Of course, the whole purpose of this session was to bring those thoughts to the surface. Catra peeked open and saw Angella sitting across from her in the same position.

"It's okay. You need to talk about these things." Angella reassured her. The sweat forming on the girl's cheek told her that these were bad memories.

"I don't want to…" Catra growled quietly.

Angella sighed. "Then how can you ever hope to confront the person responsible?"

Catra's growls increased in volume. "Because there are people counting on me. Waiting for me to return!"

Angella watched her carefully. "I thought you didn't have a home."

Catra gasped in shock, then turned away angrily. "I don't. But there is someone important to me stuck there."

"Can you tell me where that is?"

Catra eyed her carefully. "No." She spoke tensely.

Angella nodded. "Okay. That's fine. As long as you think about that place as we talk."

Catra was surprised she let it go so easily. She nodded in return and had to tiptoe around the subject of why she had run away.

"Miss Angella…"

The older woman looked back at the entrance of the kitchen and saw Catra standing there nervously. The teen had been staying there for some time now. They had provided her with a couch to sleep on and meals every day.

“I need your help with something.” Catra whispered. She had thought about asking Glimmer but thought it would be too much for her to bare. They weren’t exactly best friends, either.

Angella nodded and cleaned up her hands, then followed her to the bathroom. She saw a camera sitting on the counter and rose a brow.

“Catra, what is going on?” Angella asked honestly.

“Eh! I know this looks awkward, but just let me explain!” Catra exclaimed, waving her hands around. “Just come in and shut the door. I don’t want Glimmer to know.”

Angella started to frown but shut the door anyway. “You don’t want Glimmer to know what?”

Catra sighed and sat on the edge of the tub. “I know you’ve been working with me to talk about my past, and it has helped. I understand myself a bit better now. But I have to face the truth head on, people are going to ask about it once this is all over…”

Catra stood back up and started rolling her shirt off. Angella quickly covered her eyes, not knowing what Catra was trying to do. She peeked up again when Catra’s shuffling stopped. She gasped and dropped her hand.

Catra stood with her back to the woman, showcasing the physical evidence of her past. Scars lined her back, peaking out over the front her shoulders. Some looked old and faded, others looked relatively new.

Angella couldn’t believe what she was seeing. “Catra… Who did this to you?”

“Heh, she’s the one I’m going to be confronting in the end. But I need your help in case something happens to me. That camera,” Catra motioned to the device on the counter. “I need you to take photos of this. That way there’s no question about what happened to me and people will start to question things.”

“Catra, we should go to the police! Whatever happened, this is abuse!” Angella pleaded.

Catra shook her head and waited for her to take the photo. Angella sighed and took a few pictures to please the girl. “Why don’t you want the police involved?”

Catra glared at the floor. “Because she’s a monster, and she’ll hurt other kids until someone stops her.”

Angella gaped and Catra realized she’d said too much. The girl quickly threw her shirt back on and snatched the photos. “Thanks! Don’t worry, I’ll tell the police eventually!” Catra yelled as she dashed away.

Angella stared at the floor. She was starting to put the pieces together. She deduced that Catra had either been in a foster home or an orphanage and was being abused. The girl was worried about other kids she left behind. And the orphanage had been under a lot of scrutiny lately.

“Mom? What’re you doing?” Glimmer stopped in the hallway when she saw her mom simply standing in the bathroom.

Her mother sighed. “Nothing, just cleaning up. Come, dinner is almost ready.”

Finale

Chapter Summary

> Things get worse before it gets better, but it can only go up from here, right?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

A month had gone by since Catra's disappearance. Most of the orphans and staff had forgotten about her, or at least acted like she had never been there. On the other hand, it was all Adora could even think about. She wanted to go out and find her, but then she remembered their last conversation. Catra didn't want her to follow her, didn't want her to risk her own future.

Riko couldn't help but to think about Catra as well. She didn't know what her plans were, but she certainly hadn't expected for Catra to be gone this long, at least not without telling someone.

Riko sighed as she thought. The kids were walking to school like normal. She had gotten used to her new roommate and started letting her walk to school with her and Kohaku. The three of them were chatting about homework when Riko noticed something as they passed an alley. A shadow dashed behind some trash.

"You two keep going, I'll catch up." Riko said and wandered into the alley.

Her friends shrugged and continued forward. They trusted Riko knew what she was doing. Riko cautiously looked around. "Hello?"

A rustle was heard, and suddenly someone stepped out from behind a dumpster.

“Catra!?”

“Heh, the one and only.” Catra said with a smirk, then frowned. “Listen, I’m only here to warn you.”

“Warn me? About what? You know people are worried about you?!” Riko yelled. She started to notice the lean muscle Catra had built up in the past month.

“Tch, whatever, listen! You need to get out of there by tonight.” Catra said.

Riko loosened up and listened carefully. “Why? What’s going to happen?”

Catra crossed her arms. “Like I’m going to tell you. I don’t want you involved in this, but I’m going to fix things.”

Riko started having suspicions but kept quiet about them. “I’m not abandoning those kids. They need me. If something is going to happen, then I’m staying.”

“You’re so stubborn. At least tell Adora to leave.” Catra said, starting to turn away from her.

Riko blinked, then smiled. “I’ll tell her but we both know she won’t listen to that.”

Catra watched as Riko turned to walk about. “Just be careful.”

Riko glanced over her shoulder. “You too.”

Riko tried to get through her day like normal, but she couldn’t help but to think about what Catra had planned.

As the kids were returning from school, Riko saw Adora. “Adora!”

The girl stopped and let the girl run up to her. “Hey, I got to tell you something!” Then she leaned in close so only she could hear. “You need to get out of the orphanage tonight.”

Adora's brows furrowed. "What does that mean?"

Riko smirked and dashed inside with her friends. "Don't ask me, I'm just passing on the message."

Adora stood there for a minute trying figure out what that meant. '*Passing on the message*… Catra!'

"Riko, wait up!"

Korra read the paper over and over again. She had been finishing paperwork in her office when an officer knocked and delivered an envelope. She thought nothing over it until she opened it and saw documents from the orphanage. She flipped the manila envelope over, looking for a return address or something to indicate who sent it, but found none. Someone had hand-delivered it.

Korra marched from the office to the security room and explained to the men what she needed. She waited as they pulled up security footage of the front entrance from the day. They fast-forwarded it until they suddenly saw a shadowy figure stop at the door.

"There! Go back." Korra ordered.

They watched as someone slid an envelope in the crack of the door and ran away. Korra couldn't quite make out who it was. They had a hood on. Just from the footage, she could reason that it was a young girl, either tan or of another culture, who had a tail. That was her biggest clue and Korra only just caught sight of it as the figure dashed away.

'This is that missing girl.'

She quickly said her thanks and rushed back to her office. She started diving in to all of the different documents: incident forms, school reports, injury reports, history of several kids. Reading the

backgrounds of some of these kids was heart wrenching. She recognized one of the names as she skimmed through them.

Name: Riko

'That's one of Asami's students.' Korra thought. 'Why don't they have last names?'

Age: 15

Race: Earthbender

History: Stranded when her parents were robbed and witnessed their deaths. No other family is known to be alive to take care of her. Often seen helping others but struggles with grief. Further appointments are recommended…

Korra scoffed. She could only hope that the girl received some kind of treatment. There was one more file after Riko's which caught Korra's attention.

Name: Catra

Age: 16

Race: Magicat

History: Abandoned when her parents were killed in a house fire, suspected arson. No one stepped up to take care of her. Often insubordinate and acts out, fighting and arguing with others. May develop abandonment issues…

The report when on with a list of Catra's incidents. Then a photo fell from her file.

Korra rose a brow as she picked it up. It was different from the other photos on file, taken with a different camera. On the back of it had 'I'm not the only one' written in marker. She pondered over it for a second before flipping it over. Her eyes went wide. She just stared at it for a minute. The photo was of someone's back

covered in large scars; scars much too big for a child to have at all.

Korra glanced back at the file. ‘This is Catra… And she’s not the only one apparently.’

Korra stomped to her feet and rushed to get a search warrant ready. There was no time to waste.

Catra had to hurry. She knew once her evidence was received, the police would hopefully act fast. She just handed them physical proof of the abuse happening behind closed doors. Files of the most abused kids. Incident reports of “accidents.” She had snuck the files from the documents room when she left with the sole purpose of shedding light on the events happening at Horde Orphanage. The only thing that she was still wondering was why Weaver picked some kids to abuse over other kids. Many of them had done similar things to get into trouble, but everyone had different outcomes. It didn’t make sense.

The Sun had finally set. Lights of the city began coming to life. Catra smirked. Now was the time. She’d spent a whole month training with Glimmer and Angella. She wasn’t as skilled as the older woman, but Catra felt she was ready to confront her abuser.

Her tail swung back and forth as she prepared herself to climb the building. This was the easy part: breaking back in. She jumped from window to window until she reached the top floor.

She slid the window open and just stood inside momentarily, taking in the environment. It was like nothing had changed. What did she expect? She could hear a quiet commotion coming from downstairs, which was normal because it was where the recreation room was. There wasn’t much actually in the rec room, two couches and a television, but kids still hung out there until curfew.

Catra began walking down the hall quietly. Her fists were balled up, ready to strike her foe. She headed in the direction of the Headmistress's office, surprised no one had seen her and called for help yet.

Riko had been sitting in one of the chairs outside the office when she heard light steps approaching. She looked up and gasped. Her mind started racing. There was another kid waiting with her and one still in the office. She grabbed the little boy's arm and pulled him out of his seat.

"You need to go. Don't worry about Weaver." She ordered.

The boy looked at her with confusion, then gasped when Catra finally appeared. She looked different, stronger, and felt calmer than before. "Catra…" The boy whispered, then ran off like Riko ordered.

Catra flexed her claws. "You're one to give orders. You couldn't even listen to me."

Riko huffed and crossed her arms. "Like I said, there are people who need me here. I can't leave them." She started to smirk. "And now that I know what you're doing here, you're not getting by without my help."

Catra grunted and pushed past her. "I don't need your help. I've been training this whole time for this moment. I'm going to destroy her."

Riko grabbed her arm. "Let me help…"

Catra glared at her, then huffed with a nod.

Weaver had been scolding a young child when Riko burst through the door. "Riko!"

Riko pushed back the fear erupting in her chest. "S-Sorry for the interruption, Headmistress!" She didn't bother with an explanation, just grabbed the young girl and dashed back out.

“Riko! You insolent child!” Weaver didn’t get to finish her statement when Catra appeared in the doorway once the earthbender was gone.

“Catra, what a surprise.” Weaver spoke, almost happy. “I wasn’t sure what happened to you. I had kind of hoped you would’ve just disappeared completely.”

Catra chuckled. “Well, here I am. And I’m here for you.” She then glared at the woman. “You have been hurting kids for far too long. You were supposed to take care of us! Instead you’ve given us the worst lives possible!”

“Oh Catra, such ignorance.” Weaver spoke, walking around the room like there wasn’t a threat in front of her.

“Ignorance? What’re you talking about?” Catra questioned.

Riko stood quietly outside of the room after getting the child to safety, waiting for a chance to help the girl.

“Yes, ignorance. You do remember how this city was formed, right?” Weaver began. Catra was about to nod, but Weaver continued anyway. “This city was formed as an alliance between nations. It was supposed to be a safe place for people from all over the world to come together and show that peace can be had… But it didn’t start like that… In the beginning, there was much violence. People couldn’t put their differences aside. It seemed like a failure from the start.”

Catra’s brows knitted together. “That doesn’t explain why you’re here, managing an orphanage.”

Weaver let out a dark chuckle. “It does actually, and it also explains why you’re here.”

Shock spread through Catra’s chest as she tried to connect the dots. “You… You’re telling me my family was killed because of who we were?!”

“Heh, it was never known for certain, but at the time there were still people who didn’t agree with having a peaceful city and targeted people that they deemed as outsiders.” Weaver explained.

Catra was starting to see red. She remembered what happened 10 years ago. Her family home was set on fire. Her father died trying to carry Catra and her mother to safety, and her mother died from her injuries. They never found out who was responsible.

“Shut up already!” A voice yelled.

Catra gasped, not realizing she was crying. A figure ran past her, raising a leg to kick Weaver. Weaver caught it easily and sent the earthbender flying. She landed with a loud thud and grabbed her back.

“Riko! Are you crazy?!” Catra yelled.

Riko gave a painful smirk. “Maybe just a little.”

“Ah, you’ve returned, too.” Weaver spoke, the odd happiness back in her voice. “I could tell you about your past, too.”

Riko stood up with a grunt. “Yeah, yeah, people don’t always get along. I heard it already. I don’t need you to repeat it.”

Catra willed her tears away, claws now at the ready. “You sure about this?”

Riko nodded, a true smirk appearing. “Hell yeah, I’d love for nothing more than to kick her ass.”

The duo glared at the Headmistress as she laughed. “I’d like to see you try.”

They grit their teeth and moved to attack at the same time.

Korra took the paperwork to the court office herself. She couldn't sit around and wait for some lackey to bum around and not get this done. She handed over the papers to a judge, who luckily wasted no time in signing them, and ran back to her car. She didn't need to head back to the station. Her squad was already on the way to the orphanage.

Riko and Catra landed painfully. Weaver was stronger than they thought. She had always paralyzed them with fear before. They hadn't anticipated another power waiting for them beyond that.

Catra recovered quicker and raised her hand to attack again. Weaver dodged and struck with her shadows, but Catra dodged them this time. She jumped up and kicked Weaver in the chest, knocking the air from her lungs momentarily.

Riko was back on her feet and punched the ground, sending a small earthquake at Weaver, knocking her to the ground. "Now, Catra!"

Catra smirked as the opportunity finally showed itself. She punched Weaver square in the face. Weaver screamed and squirmed on the ground.

The kids felt proud of themselves, until new, sinister energy rolled through the room. "You!" Weaver began to slowly stand back up, holding a hand to her face. The kids frowned, the energy coursing new fear through them. Weaver was holding up her mask. They saw cracks appear in her mask and watched as the pieces finally fell to the ground. They gasped as, even through her fingers, they could see scars across Weaver's face.

"It's kids like you two that are the reason *I'm* here! No one wants outsiders like you! And I gladly take them in to punish them for their family's sins!"

The teens stood there stunned. Weaver punished kids based on if they were different?

Weaver never dropped her hand from her face, deciding to fight with just one hand. Shadows swam towards the kids at lightspeed. The swift motion of her hand left them breathless and unable to react.

Riko peeked in eye open. She felt herself bleeding from somewhere. She felt her side and realized Weaver had solidified her shadows. A dark spear had stabbed her in the stomach. She coughed, struggling for air. She looked over through blurry vision and saw Catra was struggling with the same shadows. Weaver had struck them both with one hand. Riko touched the spear, trying to pull it away, but it was no use. Her strength was quickly fading.

Suddenly a roar erupted from beside her. She glanced up and her eyes widened as she watched Catra force the shadows out of her own shoulder with animal-like strength.

"This ends today, Weaver! We're no longer your dogs to kick around! And I'm going to make sure you never lay a hand on a kid ever again!" Catra yelled, eyes now wild.

Weaver had no choice but to pull the shadows from Riko's body as Catra moved in to attack. Riko collapsed on the ground having no strength left.

Catra nearly lost control of herself. The animal side of her was angry at Weaver for hurting Riko as badly as she did. She was angry that Weaver admitted to targeting specific kids.

Her now swifter movements caught the woman off-guard. Weaver had to step away quickly to avoid her attacks. Catra swiped with her claws, not caring where she hit, as long as she hit the Headmistress.

A quick slash to the left finally cut into Weaver's right arm. Another and her left side was scratched. Weaver was starting to tire and Catra took the opportunity again. She quickly slashed

upwards in an uppercut motion and scraped Weaver's entire torso. The woman yelled out and finally collapsed.

In the distance, they could hear heavy footsteps running through the entire building. Catra smirked. Looked like the police were finally getting their act together. She turned back to her caretaker, determined to end things before the police found them.

"Catra…"

The cat-girl looked back, anguished at the sight of her friend. "Don't kill her. Let her rot in jail for all of the shit she's done to us." Riko spoke hoarsely.

Catra flexed her claws again, ready to kill her. "Would death be too easy for you?" Catra questioned, mostly talking to herself. "You've prepared me for this moment. Hardened me until I didn't care about anything, ready to fight anyone."

Riko struggled to pull herself up to stop her. "She did it to me, too. But I'm not a hardened killer and neither are you. Don't do this!"

Catra squeezed her eyes shut as she fought with herself internally. She wanted Weaver dead, no doubt about it, but was Riko right? Would this be too easy of a punishment?

As she thought, she heard a loud rumble. She opened her eyes instantly and gasped. An earth wall stood strong in front of her. Sharp shadows pierced through it, stopping short of killing Catra.

Riko smirked, blood dripping down her chin, her fist smashed in the ground. She was thrilled that she had saved her friend in time.

Catra glared down at the shadows and wasted no thoughts snapping the spears in half. Weaver screamed again, trying to pull the shadows back to her.

The sounds of heavy boots were quickly finding them. Catra glanced back as officers stepped into the room, guns at the ready.

Catra tiredly held her hands up, but it seemed the police weren't worried about the kids. They surrounded the Headmistress with their guns pointed at her. Catra couldn't believe her eyes, they were finally going to get justice.

"Erhem…"

Catra saw another officer walk in, but she was dressed differently than the others. She must be a ranked officer. The woman took a good look at the kids and grabbed her radio. "We're going to need two buses ASAP. Over."

The woman than kneeled next to Riko and helped her sit up. "Who are you?" Riko asked, coughing.

She smiled. "Commander Korra Sato. A friend sent me."

Riko gave a tired smile back. "Karina?"

Korra stood up. "Maybe. You also helped." She stated as she turned to Catra. "I know it was you that slipped those documents to us."

Catra dismissed it with a wave of her hand. "Don't know what you're talking about."

"Heh, sure you don't. Now come over here to help me with your friend. Do you know if there's a first-aid kit nearby? The medics won't arrive for another 5 minutes at best." Korra said.

Catra nodded, finding some bandages to cover her wound for the time being.

"How are you holding up?" Catra asked as she fixed the bandages to her stomach.

Riko let out a watery chuckle. "I'm fine. What about yourself?"

Catra shook her head. "Now that this is all over, I think we're all going to be a lot better."

They heard something clatter up the stairs. The medics had arrived. Korra laid a hand on either of their shoulders.

"Listen, the medics are going to drive you two separately to the hospital. There's going to be a lot that we need to talk about, but for now worrying about recovering from your night here. I'll be right behind you after I finish up here." Korra explained. "It's going to be a rough road ahead, but it should be smoothing out soon."

Catra nodded her thanks and Korra moved to allow the medics to evacuate the injured girls.

Korra walked towards the Headmistress, who had by now been handcuffed and read her rights. She kneeled in front of her with a scowl. "I almost wish we arrived a little later. She deserved to kill you after all you've done."

Weaver chuckled. "I had hoped she would, but she's still too weak."

Korra grit her teeth quietly and hauled the woman to her feet. "No, they're stronger than the rest of us."

Nurses moved quickly back and forth, retrieving different medicines, stitching their wounds. The girls just sat there and took it. They'd been through worse.

"Hey." Riko hollered over when things began to settle down. A curtain separated them, but they could still hear each other.

"What?" Catra called back.

"Thanks for keeping your promise."

Catra sighed tiredly. She could hear the smile from the other girl. "You made the promise first. And I think you held up your end

better than I did. I heard you were always helping other kids, even if it got you in trouble."

Riko looked to the ceiling. "Yeah, well, you're the reason I don't have to do that anymore. So, thanks."

Suddenly Catra's curtain was yanked open. "Ah! Miss Angella?!"

"What were you thinking?!" Angella demanded. Riko listened with interest from the other side.

Catra fumbled with her words. "I… How- How did you even find me?!"

Korra popped her head in. "She heard what happened and came rushing over to find you. I showed her over."

Catra growled. "This… This is what I planned from the start! Lives were being ruined because of one woman!"

Angella sighed and sat down next to her. "I wish you would've told me what was really happening. I could've helped."

Catra scoffed. "You did help, remember? You made me a better, more rational fighter. I might be dead if it weren't for you."

"You'd be dead if it weren't for me!" Riko hollered.

Catra sat up with a fist. "Shut up! I'm not talking to you!"

Angella rose a brow. "Is that the person that is so important you had to go back?"

Catra settled down. "No. There's someone else there that I was really wanting to help."

"Aw, it wasn't for me?!" Riko commented.

Catra growled, ready to rip the curtain away and smack her. "You know who it is!"

Korra pulled the curtain back to Riko's side and sat down as well. "You shouldn't talk to her like that. You two helped each other."

Riko smiled and laid back into the stretcher. "I know, I'm just messing with her. We made a promise 8 years ago and then never talked to each other again until now. Just odd."

Korra smiled and patted her hand. "You know, we're going to have to have some pretty rough discussions about what happened back there, from tonight and from the past."

"Yeah, I heard you the first time."

"But not yet, in a few days when you two have healed." Korra continued.

"Where is she?!" A yell could be heard down the hall.

Korra sighed. "Let me go see who it is this time."

Riko chuckled. "I can tell you who it is. She's here for Catra."

Korra rose a brow and walked through the curtain again. "Excuse me miss, can I help you?

A blonde-haired girl was gasping for air and she had apparently run there. "I'm looking for Catra. She's my… uh, roommate."

Korra smiled and escorted her to the girl.

"Adora?!"

"Catra! Oh my, I'm so glad to see you!" Adora yelled, smothering the girl in a hug.

"Ah, Adora, stop it!" Catra exclaimed with a painful smile.

Adora gasped. "You're hurt!"

"Yeah, that's kinda why I'm here. Duh." Catra responded.

Tears threatened to fall from Adora's eyes. Catra gulped and stuttered an apology in panic.

"You don't have to apologize. I'm just happy to have you back." Adora cried and grabbed her hand.

Angella watched all of this quietly. "Catra, is *this* the one you had to go back for?"

Catra chuckled and nodded. "Yeah, she's the one."

The two girls stared at each other, completely in love whether they knew it or not.

Angella nodded and stood up. "It seems you're in good hands then. I'll be heading home. Oh, and Catra…" The girls looked at her. "My door is always open for you. You're welcome to come back anytime."

Catra glanced back at Adora, then back at Angella. "Adora, too?"

Angella smiled. "Adora, too."

Catra couldn't help the hope that began to creep into her chest. Maybe this was their chance.

Adora rose a brow. "Who was that?"

Catra laughed. "I guess I have some explaining to do."

When Riko woke up again, she was in a different room. It was an actual private room. She sighed, happy to be out of the ER. She made a mental note to find Catra later.

Some time later, a knock came on her door. She smiled when she saw the officer from last night. "Hey, Commander."

Korra smiled and held the door open. "Hey, kid. I brought a guest with me."

Riko gasped. “Mrs. Sato?!”

Asami laughed and waved. “Yes, hi there Riko.”

“What’re you doing here?!” Riko exclaimed.

Korra rubbed the back of her head. “Do you not remember when I introduced myself? ‘Commander Korra *Sato*.’ As in, Asami’s my wife?”

“Asami?! That’s your first name?” Riko asked.

Korra smacked her forehead. “Maybe that was too much info at once.”

Riko waved frantically with one hand. “No, no! Just, come sit. We can talk.” Asami thanked her and pulled Korra down to sit with them. “I’m still a bit confused. Why are you here, Mrs. Sato?”

Asami took a breath, preparing to explain herself. “Your friend approached me awhile back. She mentioned that you were hurt.”

Riko thought back to the day when she showed Karina her arm. She growled. “Karina…”

Asami nodded. “Yes, Karina. She brought her assignment with her to my desk so you wouldn’t suspect anything. She knew you were scared. She had written the name on her paper and pointed to it as she spoke. It was the name of the woman in charge of the orphanage.”

Shock filled Riko’s body the more the woman talked.

“She said you needed help but was too afraid to reach out. From there, I asked the other teachers to keep an eye on you, and I asked Korra to investigate it.”

“And man, when things finally got some light, whew, was there a lot of shit wrong with that place.” Korra interjected.

The room went silent as they allowed Riko a moment to process everything.

"Okay…" Riko rubbed her forehead. "Okay, I'm okay with that. But why are you telling me all of this?"

"Well…" Korra began but looked to her wife to finish.

Asami sighed. "We were under the impression that you still need a home. I wanted you to know my involvement before you made a choice."

Riko couldn't believe her ears. "Are you…"

Asami nodded. "If you want to, we would like to open our home to you. I know you're going to age out of the system soon. Most kids your age in your situation would rather wait it out and run away once they're 18. But it's better late than never, right?"

Asami was blathering at this point, nerves finally catching up to her. Riko still didn't believe her ears and rubbed them to make sure she was hearing correctly. Tears crept to her eyes. Then she jolted up with a lightbulb moment. This was her chance.

"I would like that, on one condition…"

Catra held Adora's hand as she guided her to Angella's home. After her recovery in the hospital, the duo wasted no at the orphanage, simply going back for their few belongings. Catra smiled as the apartment came into view.

"So, this is where you were for a month?" Adora asked.

Catra looked over excitedly. "Yeah! They do all sorts of cool things here. You'll like it."

Catra pushed open the shop door and a bell rang above them. Glimmer looked up from the counter with a gasp.

“Ah, Catra! You’re back!” Glimmer shouted and ran up to hug her. Then she quickly pulled away with a cough, acting like she hadn’t missed her.

They heard footsteps coming down the stairs, somewhat quicker than usual. “Catra?” Angella peaked down the stairs and smiled. “You have returned.”

Catra stood up straight and held her head high. “Yes, Miss Angella. And I brought Adora with me.”

Angella waved her off, urging her to stop acting so formal, then laid a gentle hand on Adora’s shoulder. “Come, we have things to discuss if you’re going to be staying here.”

“W-Wait, like long-term?” Adora questioned, looking back at Catra who looked just as confused.

Angella then grabbed some papers from the counter and showed them to the girls. They gasped and their hearts jumped in joy. ‘Adoption’ was stamped in bold letters at the top.

“I figured if you were coming back here, then it should be official, so you have a place to fall back on and people you can count on.” Angella explained.

Adora teared up and she wanted to hug the woman she just met. Catra hung her head, claws digging into her palm. Without looking, she marched up to the woman and hugged her tight. Angella felt her tears land on her blouse. Adora now felt like she could join in the hug.

“Thank you.” She cried, saying the words that Catra couldn’t find.

Angella nodded in understanding and patted her head.

“I’m finally going to have sisters?!” Glimmer yelled.

Riko smiled from the passenger seat of her math teacher's car. She watched the city whiz by her as they drove to school. It was almost a thrill; they had barely even been in a car before.

Asami slowed to a stop in front of the elementary school. She jumped out and opened the back door for the youngest child.

Nami hopped from her seat with a smile no one had ever seen before, except on the day she moved out of the orphanage. She gave Asami a big hug. Asami laughed and adjusted her bookbag so it wouldn't fall from her shoulders, then urged her to go inside the school.

As Asami hopped back into the driver's seat, Riko saw a pack from the corner of her eye. "Ah, crap! She forgot her lunch!"

Riko dove from the car just as Asami was shifting gears, causing her to slam on the brakes. "Riko, be more careful!"

Riko laughed and ran after the girl. "Nami! Hey, you forgot your lunch!"

Nami heard her just as she approached the front doors and stopped, smiling at the older girl. "Thanks, sis!" She grabbed the pack and walked in.

Riko rubbed her head, catching her breath. "No problem… sis."

She walked back to the car and slumped into her seat. Asami rose a brow. "What's up?"

Riko slowly smiled and glanced to her new mother. "She called me sis."

"That's great!" Kohaku yelled from the backseat.

Asami smiled and patted her head. "That is great. That means she's adjusting." Then she let go of the brakes and continued driving to the high school.

Riko waved at her math teacher, now surrogate mother, once they arrived. “Thanks for the ride, I’ll see you in class, *Ma*.”

Riko laughed as Asami cringed. “You don’t have to call me that. It’s bad enough you make fun of my first name now.”

“Aw, c’mon, give it some time. It’ll grow on you!” Riko said, walking with Kohaku towards the school.

Asami sighed and pulled away from the street to find parking.

“Riko!”

The girl winced, preparing herself. Her best friend pulled her into a tight hug. “I’ve missed you so much! I’m so glad you’re back!” Karina exclaimed.

Riko sighed, being dragged down the hall. “It’s good to see you too.”

She yelped as she was abruptly brought up to stand straight. She gasped when she saw tears in her friend’s eyes. “H-Hey, I’m sorry! Did I do something?!”

She yelped again Karina shoved her away. “I was so worried about you. I heard what happened at the orphanage. That you fought with Weaver and was severely injured.

Riko blinked and stepped back up. “Then why didn’t you visit me in the hospital?”

The tears finally fell from Karina’s eyes. “I didn’t want to overwhelm you. You were hurt. You were being questioned by the police. The Sato’s were completing adoption papers. That’s a lot for one person to deal with at once.”

Riko rose a brow, not understanding. “Why would having you there overwhelm me?”

They practically glared at each other from their frustration with each other.

Suddenly Karina stepped closer to her, way too close for personal space. Riko couldn't ponder over her personal bubble for long when she felt something soft on her lips. She froze. Karina grabbed her chin and pulled her closer. Riko finally processed what was happening and pushed back.

Karina pulled away once Riko kissed her back. "You see why that would be overwhelming?" She asked quietly.

Riko laid her head on her shoulder, cheeks burning up. "Yeah, I understand now."

Karina chuckled and grabbed her hand, pulling her to class. "It took you like 30 seconds to respond."

Riko's blush deepened. "I-I was surprised! I didn't think you'd like me like that."

Karina turned around, stopping mid-walk. "Do you think I would still be friends with you, after figuring out you had a crush on me, if I *didn't* like you back?"

Riko chuckled nervously and rubbed the back of her head. "I don't know. I didn't even know *you* knew about that until recently."

Karina smiled and began walking to class again. "Well, I guess I'll say it, so you know for sure. I do like you, Riko."

Riko furiously rubbed her cheeks to stop from blushing, making Karina laugh. Together they stepped into math class and saw Mrs. Sato getting ready for class. She rose a brow questionably at her new daughter when she saw that they were holding hands.

"Ugh, you're right! This is too much! Here it is my first day back and the girl I like tells me she likes me back and now my math teacher is my mom!" Riko exclaimed, shaking her head.

Karina laughed and guided her to their seats. Asami said no word about anything that had happened, trying to help Riko transition back into a regular life.

As they left class, Karina grabbed her hand. Riko blushed, then jolted up straight when she saw something in the distance down the hall, and smiled.

Catra saw Riko and her ‘friend’ exiting the math room. She squeezed Adora closer to her. Seeing Riko made her remember that night, but that was behind them now. She was glad Riko appeared to be moving on as well.

Adora smiled, admiring how Catra wrapped an arm around her shoulder, not caring what people thought.

Riko and Catra met eyes, both remembering their past. Riko smiled and waved at her. Catra smirked and motioned towards Adora, now her girlfriend. Riko smiled brightly, almost jumping up and down with joy. Catra was sure if they were closer, she’d be able to hear Riko’s cheering.

And they didn’t avert their eyes anymore.

Chapter End Notes

If you actually read this far, kudos to you! This was just a combo fan project between me and a friend.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!